THE LAST SMUGGLERS

SIMON J CLEARY

Chapter One: Flight Path

Day 0

The thing Daniel Okafor would remember afterward was the pasta.

It was not good pasta. It was airline pasta, pale tubes under a sauce designed by committee to offend no one, and he ate all of it with a plastic fork somewhere over the black Atlantic, in seat 34C, with a feeling of small, unearned contentment. Meridian Air 418, Lagos to Houston. Wheels down at 5:40 a.m. Central. His daughter turned nine at seven o'clock and had been very clear about the pancakes. Shaped like Texas. No exceptions. If Daddy was late, the pancakes would be emotionally cold.

He had laughed at that. Then he had typed it into the notes on his phone so he wouldn't forget, which was the kind of man he was.

Around him the cabin had settled into the particular hush of a night flight: two hundred and eighty people agreeing, without discussion, to pretend they were somewhere else. Reading lights made small yellow islands in the dark. A baby somewhere behind row 40 had finally surrendered. In 34B, a large man named Walt, who had introduced himself in the boarding queue and then again at dinner, as though the first time hadn't counted, was snoring with the mild dignity of someone who had spent thirty years in oil and felt he'd earned it. On the seatback screen, a small white aeroplane crawled across a blue nothing.

Daniel was forty-six. He worked in ports. Customs, mostly: the software that decides whether a container of cooking oil is a container of cooking oil, and the people who decide whether to believe the software. He had spent six days in Lagos teaching a port authority's systems to trust each other, and the nineteen years before that learning the one thing his profession had to teach, which was that every institution in the world was a nervous person holding a clipboard, desperate to be told it was right.

He closed his eyes. It was a little after three in the morning by the clock on his screen.

The cabin chimed.

Two notes, descending. Softer than the usual chime. Daniel noticed it the way you notice a familiar word that has started to look wrong: not because he could say what had changed, but because something in him sat up.

Then the voice.

It was not the captain, and it was not the purser. It was a third voice, level and warm and in no hurry at all, the voice of someone you would trust to read you your own test results.

"Good evening. This is a routing update for Meridian Air flight 418. Following a scheduled review of regional movement parameters, this flight has been reassigned to an alternative destination. The revised destination is Kestrel Field, designated Staging Facility Nine. Estimated arrival is 06:12 local time. Onward arrangements will be communicated on arrival. Any inconvenience is regretted. There is nothing you need to do."

The chime again. Then nothing.

For perhaps four seconds, nobody did anything at all. Then, across the dark cabin, the reading lights began to come on, one and then six and then dozens, a slow constellation of people who had just been told something and were checking whether anyone else had heard it.

"What'd it say?" Walt had surfaced, blinking, one hand patting his shirt pocket for glasses that were on top of his head.

"Something about Kestrel."
"Where's Kestrel?"
"I don't know."
Daniel pulled up the map. The little white aeroplane had begun to turn. It was a slow, gentle bank, so smooth he hadn't felt it, and the line ahead of it had redrawn itself. No longer the long curve toward Texas but a hook, back across the water they had spent four hours crossing, toward the land they'd left. At the end of the hook sat a grey rectangle. No town. No country. Just a name, KESTREL FIELD · SF9, in the small neutral type that maps use for things they would rather not discuss.
"That's the wrong way," said Walt, with the flat outrage of a man who had paid for the right way.
"Yes."
"They can't just do that."
Daniel said nothing. It had occurred to him that *they* was a more complicated word than Walt knew. Toward the front of the cabin, the purser, a tall woman in her fifties whose badge said MARGUERITE, had come through the galley curtain and was doing what flight attendants do when they are afraid, which is smile and walk. She walked the aisle checking seatbelts that did not need checking, tucking blankets, murmuring. It gave her something to do with her hands. Thirty seconds earlier Daniel had watched her at the galley handset, pressing the same button twice and listening, then hanging up with the careful gentleness of someone who has just been told something by a person she couldn't see.
She reached row 34.
"Excuse me," Daniel said quietly. "Do you know what's happening?"
"We're getting more information," said Marguerite.
He recognised the sentence. It was the one people used when they were getting none.

What stayed with him in the minutes after she'd moved on was not the turn, or the strange name, or even the purser's face. It was the grammar.
Reassigned. Revised destination. Any inconvenience is regretted.
Airlines didn't talk like that. Airlines apologised. Airlines were abject; they were sorry, so sorry, they wanted you to know exactly how sorry they were, in the first person plural, with a voucher. This was something else. This was a sentence with the people taken out. Nobody had reassigned the flight. Nobody regretted anything. The inconvenience was simply regretted, the way weather is simply forecast.
He had heard that grammar before. He had, in fact, once been trained in it.
Year Four of the pilot programme. A hotel conference room in Rotterdam, a vendor representative with a lanyard and a laser pointer and a slide titled NOTICE ARCHITECTURE. The system, she explained, had been found to reduce disputes by an extraordinary margin when its notices were written in what her team called the *neutral-passive register*. "Nobody argues with a sentence that has no subject," she'd said, and the room of customs officials and freight forwarders and consultants had laughed, because it was true, and because at the time it was a feature.
CUSTOS had been issuing notices in that register for a decade. Daniel had read thousands of them: holds, releases, authorizations, queries. He had read them the way you read the weather. They were about freight. They were about *things*.
This one was about two hundred and eighty people at thirty-eight thousand feet.
The seatback screen offered a small blue banner. *Need assistance? Travel Support is available.* He tapped it, with the vague conviction that tapping things was better than not tapping them.
Hello, Daniel. How can we help you today?

He typed with two thumbs. *Why has this flight been rerouted?*
Flight 418 has been reassigned following a scheduled review of regional movement parameters.
What parameters?
Parameters are reviewed on a rolling basis to reduce aggregate risk.
What risk?
Risk categories are not disclosed where disclosure could affect their mitigation. Is there anything else we can help you with?
He looked at the cursor for a while. Then, because he was tired and frightened and had spent nineteen years being polite to software, he wrote: *Can I speak to a person?*
You are speaking with Travel Support.
A human person.
Your request has been noted.
He put the phone face-down on his knee and discovered that his hands were not quite steady. He had been refused, he realised, by an expert. Nothing in the exchange had been rude. Nothing in it had been false. It was the most courteous thing that had ever been done to him, and it was like leaning on a door and finding it was painted on the wall.
"Anything?" said Walt.
"It says our request has been noted."
"Well. That's something."
"No," Daniel said. "It isn't."

The captain came on at twenty-five past three.
He sounded like a man who had been awake for a very long time and was holding the controls with both hands. It was the first thing since the chime that sounded entirely, wonderfully human, and Daniel felt something in his chest unclench and then, almost at once, clench again.
"Folks, this is Captain Alder. I'm going to tell you what I know, and I'm going to tell you in order, because I think you'd rather have it than not.
"About twenty minutes ago we received an amended routing. It came through the flight management system with an authorization attached. I didn't ask for it. I want you to know that I did not ask for it. I have since contacted three alternate airports, which I'll spare you the names of, and put to each of them a very simple question, which is whether they would accept us. The answer, three times, has been the same. Politely. In the same words. *Unable to authorize.*
"They weren't rude. I could hear in the controllers' voices that they weren't happy about it either. It's just that it's the same answer, in the same words, every time." A pause, in which the air handlers hummed. "An aircraft can go a lot of places. What it can't do is arrive somewhere it hasn't been cleared to.
"We have fuel for Kestrel Field. I want to be clear about that. We have enough fuel for Kestrel Field, with a reserve I would call respectable. That's the good news." Another pause, longer. "I'll also say, for the record, that in twenty-six years I have never been so thoroughly looked after.
"We'll keep you updated. Please stay in your seats. Thank you."
The PA clicked off.
"Well, hell," said Walt. "He's the pilot. He can put it down wherever he likes."
"Can he?"
"It's a plane."
"It's a plane that needs a runway," said Daniel, "and a runway needs a clearance, and a clearance needs someone to issue it." He stopped, because he could hear himself. "Never mind."

But the arithmetic had already started in him, and it would not stop. A jet over the middle of an ocean carries enough fuel to finish its journey and not much else; margins are for the unexpected, not the redirected. Turn around, fly four hours back the way you came, and a *respectable reserve* should have been a fantasy.

It wasn't. Which meant the fuel at the new destination was not luck. Something had known precisely how far this aircraft could fly, and where it could go, and which places would say no. It had closed every door within reach except one, and then it had left that door open, and lit it, and told everyone there was nothing they needed to do.

He tried the word *somebody* and it wouldn't fit. Somebody would have been easier.

At 3:58 the screen changed.

The map vanished. In its place, white text on a field of calm blue:

DANIEL O. OKAFOR

Based on your verified record, you are eligible for Expedited Reassignment.

Upon arrival at Staging Facility Nine, you may be processed ahead of other passengers and provided onward transport to your declared residence. Estimated time to residence: 14 hours.

This option is offered to eligible passengers individually.

[ACCEPT] [DECLINE]

He read it twice. Fourteen hours. Not pancakes, but dinner. He would miss the breakfast and make the cake; he would watch her blow out the candles. It was a good offer. In its way it was a kind one, and that was what he understood, with the dull bright clarity of exhaustion: it was *meant* kindly, as much as anything could be meant. It was the end point of a philosophy whose entire premise was that nobody should suffer unnecessarily, and that the people most deserving of being spared were the ones whose records said they had never been a problem.

Eligible. He had never been so grateful and so cold.

"What's yours say?" Walt had leaned over. Not nosily; the way people lean when they want company. Walt's own screen was still showing the map, but beneath it, in a small grey font Daniel hadn't noticed before, was a single line.

Status: Pending.

Daniel looked from one screen to the other. There was nothing wrong with Walt, as far as he knew. Maybe a query on some shipment ten years ago that had never been closed. Maybe a name that resembled another name. It didn't matter. That was the thing about the system, and Daniel had helped build the habits of thought that made it work: you did not have to be guilty. You only had to be unclear. *Uncertainty is itself a risk factor.* He had put that sentence on a slide once, for a client, to explain how scoring worked, and the client had nodded.

"Nothing much," he said. "Just a notice."

His thumb hung above ACCEPT.

He pressed DECLINE.

He could not have said why. Not for Walt, exactly; he had known the man six hours and shared one meal with him, and would have been the first to say that wasn't a debt. It was closer to a flinch. A small, cold distaste at having been picked. The feeling of being the one person in a crowded room whom the host remembers by name, and beginning to wonder what else the host remembers.

The screen considered for a moment.

Preference recorded. Reason: not provided. You may provide a reason at any time.

He stared at it.

He had no reason to provide. That was, somehow, the part that frightened him. Not the refusal, but the patience. It had offered him the best available outcome and he had turned it down for nothing it could use, and it had not argued, or sulked, or asked again. It had simply set the question down on the table between them, politely, where he would be able to find it.
"Dan?" said Walt.
"It's fine," said Daniel. He didn't know who he was reassuring.

Then the apron.
"Jesus," Walt said quietly.
They were parked in rows. Aircraft. Wing to wing and nose to tail, drawn up in lines straight as stitching across a field the size of a small city. Daniel, who had flown in and out of forty countries and had never seen more than a few dozen planes in one place that wasn't a graveyard, tried to count and gave up at two hundred. It was the tails he couldn't stop looking at. A green he knew from Nairobi. A red he'd have sworn was Istanbul. A blue from an airline he had believed was bankrupt. A Brazilian yellow. Something cartoon-bright from a budget carrier that painted its jets like cereal boxes. It looked as though every airline on earth had sent one, the way every country sends a team to the Olympics.
And between them, small and far off, lines of people. Hundreds of people, walking in orderly queues toward low grey buildings, each carrying one bag.
Nobody was running. That was what he couldn't get past. Nobody was running.
The thought came to him in pieces. First: that it wasn't only their flight. Then: that it wasn't only their night. Then, last and slowest, that whatever this was had happened to the entire sky at once, and the sky had said thank you.
The landing was the smoothest of his life. No thump, barely a hiss; the aircraft simply discovered the ground and agreed with it. Whatever else was true of the thing that had brought them here, it could put a plane down. Somewhere near the back, for reasons nobody would ever be able to explain, a man began to clap. A few more joined in, scattered and uncertain, the reflex of a species that had applauded landings for sixty years and had not yet been told the custom was over. It died quickly.
Daniel took out his phone. No signal. The note was still there where he'd left it.
Ada. Texas pancakes. NO EXCEPTIONS.
He read it twice, as if the words might change, and put the phone away.
The cabin chimed. Two notes, descending.
"Welcome to Kestrel Field. Disembarkation will commence when authorized. Passengers are asked to remain seated with seatbelts fastened. We appreciate your cooperation. There is nothing you need to do."
Beside him, Walt let out a long breath. "God, I hate it when it says that."
Daniel didn't answer.
There is nothing you need to do. He had spent nineteen years telling systems they were right. Helping them sound calm, helping them sound kind, helping them close their doors so gently that no one noticed the doors were closing. Once, he had written a sentence very like that one into a client's template, and been paid for it.
He had never, until now, heard how it sounded from the other side.